MEMORANDUM

Date: **June 15, 2015**

To: District-wide Boundary Review Advisory Committee (D-BRAC)

From: Judy Brennan, Enrollment and Transfer Director

Subject: Background information on policy issues

This memo provides background and technical information to support D-BRAC discussion of several potential areas for policy change or inclusion in the district-wide boundary review framework. Please let me know if you have any suggestions or concerns. I will be unavailable for the June 18 D-BRAC meeting but will respond to your questions as soon as possible.

When considering potential policy language changes, keep in mind that policy change requires School Board approval voted on after two public readings at least 21 days apart. If substantive change is made after the first reading, another first reading is required, and the second reading is scheduled for at least 21 days after. Changes to the administrative directive are made at the Superintendent level and do not require Board approval.

Topic: Probability-based assignment

Background**:** Brooke Cowan has presented D-BRAC with an alternative to the current single-school boundary assignment system (hard copies of her reports are available in the permanent D-BRAC meeting files). Similar systems exist in numerous other large urban school districts in the US, such as Boston, Milwaukee and Louisville. Probability-based assignment, also referred to a "controlled choice" provides a set of schools that serve a large region. Upon entry, usually at kindergarten, a new student is assigned to one of the schools. Factors that are used to determine actual placement in other districts include proximity, sibling preference and parent choice. A socio-economic balancer is often included as well. Ms. Cowan's model may include some element of parent choice, but it has not been featured in the briefs she has provided to the committee to date.

Policy impact: Current PPS policy states that students are assigned to neighborhood schools based on their address. Each address in the district boundary has guaranteed access to a single corresponding

school from grades K-12. If PPS moved to a probability-based assignment system, the policy would need to change to allow each address guaranteed access to one of several schools, with the actual school determined at the time of registration.

Discussion: Other districts using controlled choice are able to balance enrollment and economic diversity across schools more readily than districts with guaranteed school assignments. However, the trade-offs include less certainty for families and communities (siblings in one house may be together at one school, but the children next door may be assigned to different school) and more students assigned to schools that are further away from their home, causing higher transportation costs. Given the strong bond Portlanders have to the neighborhood school concept, and the interest in school-assignment certainty that was conveyed through PPS 2025 survey responses, this change would signal a major departure from the current policy and practice.

Topic: High school boundaries as part of district-wide boundary review

Background: District-wide boundary review has been described frequently as a K-8 focused initiative. There are three primary reasons for this:

- High school boundaries were addressed through high system design in 2010-11. That process did not include boundary changes at any elementary, K-8 or middle schools.
- Nearly half of elementary, K-8 or middle schools have enrollment that is outside of programmatic and capacity targets.
- Enrollment growth will impact elementary, K-8 and middle schools years before it catches up to high schools. High schools are first on the list for full modernizations, and will have flexible spaces to manage enrollment variations earlier than most schools serving lower grades

Policy impact: Neighborhood school assignment rules apply to students in grades K-12, as described in policy 4.10.045-P(III)(A). Policy and administrative directive language regarding boundary change is applied to the same grades. However, there is no explicit language that indicates changes at one school level may trigger changes at another school level.

Discussion: The guiding values drafted by D-BRAC apply to all schools with boundaries, including high schools. As such, high school boundaries may change through the district-wide process, particularly where needed to reduce overcrowding and provide sufficient enrollment to enable strong programs. Both D-BRAC and PPS 2025 survey respondents have sent strong signals that stable feeder patterns are an important factors to consider during boundary change. New boundary scenarios will include potential changes to high school boundaries in order to maintain or create concise feeder patterns.

D-BRAC may choose to recommend specific policy or administrative directive language to direct that all future boundary reviews cover grade levels K-12.

Topic: Boundary factor ranking

Background: Current policy includes six factors for consideration during boundary change. D-BRAC is currently developing revisions to the factors, to better align with the committee's guiding values. A

question has been under discussion as to whether the committee should also express a ranking or preference of the factors.

There are numerous examples of criteria for boundary change in other districts, included several pulled together by Jason Trombley, attached. Note that none of the factors listed on the attachment are ranked. Also included with this memo is an example of an impact summary created for a boundary/grade configuration change decided in 2012.

Policy impact: The current set of factors is non-prioritized. Adding a ranking would require change to policy language.

Discussion: Once revisions to boundary change factors are finalized, PPS staff will develop multiple versions of boundary maps. We plan to create maps that optimize, or realize to the greatest extent, the factors that were most important for PPS 2025 survey respondents and D-BRAC:

- Optimal use of facilities
- Intact feeder patterns
- Compact boundaries

With each scenario, staff will prepare an analysis of the impact of the proposed changes on those and other agreed-upon factors, including student body demographics, stability at other schools and number of students impacted. Our goal is to provide enough information to allow stakeholders to easily compare the scenarios based on all the factors, and to answer the questions posed in the racial equity lens.

As there will be multiple scenarios that provide opportunities to compare and contrast each factor across all schools, it is not necessary to rank boundary change factors before scenarios are drafted. Staff would like an opportunity at a future D-BRAC meeting to describe more of the steps and methodology we are planning to use to develop district-wide boundary and grade configuration scenarios.

D-BRAC has discussed two additional points of assessment that have not been part of PPS practice in the past, but have strong potential to ensure that any set of factors is applied equitably: Use of the racial equity lens and community advisory group such as D-BRAC included in boundary review process.

Topic: Scale of district-wide boundary review

Background: D-BRAC members have raised a concern that the level of review and resolution of boundary change issues is at a school-by-school level, which may be too small to take in to consideration all the issues that need to be addressed in order to meet the committee's guiding values.

Policy impact: Current policy does not specify a scale for review or change. Language that describes in quantity or quality the scale or boundary review and chance would need to be added in order to clarify the number or type of schools that should be included in order to conclude a boundary change process.

Discussion: In our current practice, enrollment issues are discovered at the school level and resolved at a regional level. Every October at least two enrollment aspects are analyzed at every school:

- Program target—Does enrollment meet a minimal threshold to operate a full program without supplemental funding?
- Utilization—Are there enough classrooms for all of the teachers assigned to a school?

This "top-down" information is combined with "bottom-up" reports—concerns generated by principals and senior directors—to develop an annual list of enrollment hot spots. Developing solutions to the identified problems is a more nuanced process. In some cases there is clear synergy of mutual interest, such as an overcrowded school adjacent to the boundary of an under-enrolled school, both of which feed to the same middle and high schools. In this instance, if no other apparent enrollment issues exist in neighboring schools, the scale of change may be limited to just two schools.

However, in most cases, and certainly in PPS today, there are multiple layers of issues and options for resolution, so no simple answer to how broadly or tightly to frame a solution. High School feeder patterns provide a scale aligned with basic district organizing principles, but it may be too big or small to result in the best possible options for change.

Current policy does not specify how many or what type of schools to include in boundary change options. This allows maximum flexibility, but it does not provide any predictable area of study to identify the best possible response to enrollment issues. The boundary change factor "program and enrollment stability in the surrounding schools" helps make sure that resolving issues at one school does not lead to greater problems at other schools, but this may not be the level of assurance D-BRAC is seeking.

When considering this and other issue for potential policy language change keep in mind that policy change requires School Board approval voted on after two public readings at least 21 days apart. Changes to the administrative directive are made at the Superintendent level and do not require Board approval.

Attachments: Research – School Boundary Process
Boundary factors comparison (2011-12 boundary change cycle)